# A Series of Unfortunate Events (TV)

## By Daniel Handler (aka Lemony Snickett) and Joe Tracz

### (based on the book The Bad Beginning: Part 1)

***Suggested Roles:*** ***ACTOR:*** *Klaus, Count Olaf, Troupe Member 2*
***ACTRESS:*** *Violet, Justice Straus, Troupe Member 1*

***NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.***

**VIOLET:** [Hello], I'm Violet Baudelaire, and this is my brother Klaus.

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** Oh, well, I am Justice Strauss of the High Court. Forgive my not shaking hands, but as you can see, I am a mountain of parcels.

**KLAUS:** We'd be more than happy to be of assistance, Justice Straus. My sister is very mechanically minded, and I'm quite adept at library science. Are you Count Olaf's wife?

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** What? Oh, oh, no, no, no. Goodness me, no. No, I don't even really know him that well. He's just my neighbor. His house is over there. *(points)*

**TOGETHER:** *(singing theme song)* ***Look away, look away . . .*

**COUNT OLAF:** Welcome to my humble home, orphans. I am Count Olaf, the renowned Actor and your new guardian. Please, come in. Wipe your feet on the mat so you don't track in any mud. And don't forget your enormous fortune.

**VIOLET:** How do you do?

**COUNT OLAF:** How do I do? Better and better, Baudelaire's. Better and better. I'm about to be rather wealthy . . .

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## INTRODUCTION

***ACTRESS:*** *Not to give away the plot or anything, but I would strongly advise all of you to leave immediately and find something far more cheerful to watch.*
***ACTOR:*** *Perhaps a cooking show. Or a documentary about baby pandas.*
***ACTRESS:*** *Unfortunately, this story is filled with miserable orphans, suspicious adults, and Count Olaf, a man whose greatest talent is committing felonies in dramatic eyeliner.*
***ACTOR:*** *But through it all, the unifying theme of this story is:*
***ACTRESS:*** *If you are smart, capable . . .*
***ACTOR:*** *. . . and under 18!*
***ACTRESS:*** *Your job is to compensate for the confidently incorrect life choices of the adults in your life.*
***TOGETHER:*** *(singing theme song) Look away, look away . . .*
***ACTOR:*** *A Series of Unfortunate Events (TV- Season 1, Episodes 1&2)*
***ACTRESS:*** *by Daniel Handler, aka Lemony Snickett and Joe Tracz*

**COUNT OLAF:** *(unfurling a paper from his pocket)* Do you know what this is?

**VIOLET:** It looks like a list.

**COUNT OLAF:** Wrong! It's a list. A list of chores. Rich brats like you probably spoiled rotten and have never done a chore in your life.

**VIOLET:** Actually, we often help around the house.

**COUNT OLAF:** *(ignoring her, he conducts a grand tour)* Welcome to your lucky life. Come with me, and I'll show you the delightful features of your home. This is the kitchen where you may help yourselves to meals. The stove is a bit like a servant. You have to whack it sometimes to get it to work. This is the yard which needs weeding, mowing and pruning. Bathroom #7, the only one you are allowed to use, has all the usual amenities, though the management regrets to inform you that the shampoo is not tear-free. If anything, it encourages tears. And this is where you will sleep, orphans.

**VIOLET:** There's only one bed.

**COUNT OLAF:** As you can see, I have provided, at no cost to you, this complimentary pile of rocks. Thoughts?

**VIOLET:** First impressions are often wrong . . .

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**COUNT OLAF:** True. Your first impression of me may be that I am a terrible person. But in time, Baudelaire's, I hope you'll come to realize. . . *(ominously)* You haven't the faintest idea.

*******Scene Change – theme song*******

**COUNT OLAF:** Why aren't you cleaning? My list was very specific.

**VIOLET:** We finished it. We even washed your underwear.

**COUNT OLAF:** You didn't. *(consults list and shows Violet)* You still have to prepare a meal for myself and my theater troupe. Now, quick, get a move on. The troupe will be here at 7:00, and in the meantime, I will be up in -- can you guess?

**VIOLET:** Your secret tower room?

**COUNT OLAF:** Wrong. My secret tower room, which you are forbidden to go into. Understood?

**VIOLET:** Forbidden.

**COUNT OLAF:** Forbidden!

*******Scene Change to Count Olaf's Parlor with his Theatre Troupe*******

**VIOLET:** *(as they watch Olaf jiving in his parlor)* Klaus, what's that thing James Brown said?

**COUNT OLAF:** *(strikes a pose)* I feel good! And a one, and a two, and a . . . *(sings)* ******It's the Count, it's the Count, it's the Count!

**TROUPE MEMBERS (BOTH):** C!

**COUNT OLAF:** Is for courageous, just another word for brave!

**TROUPE MEMBERS (BOTH):** O!

**COUNT OLAF:** Oh, my God, what a handsome knave!

**TROUPE MEMBERS (BOTH):** U!

**COUNT OLAF:** Unbelievable good looks and brains and heart!

**TROUPE MEMBERS (BOTH):** N!

**COUNT OLAF:** For the Knowledge, cause I'm very, very smart!

**TROUPE MEMBERS (BOTH):** T!

**COUNT OLAF:** For the talent – the world's greatest actor!

**TROUPE MEMBERS (BOTH):** *(sings)* It's the Count, it's the Count, it's the Count!

**COUNT OLAF:** The Count! *(slides into a bow in front of Violet)*

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**VIOLET:** *(confused)* Yes, we've met.

**COUNT OLAF:** Orphans, this is my theater troupe. And as anyone in the theater knows, after a grand entrance, the audience is supposed to applaud.

**BOTH:** *(applaud awkwardly, sharing a glance)*

*******Scene Change to Dining Room *******

**KLAUS:** *(Violet and Klaus enter with plates of food)* Dinner is served.

**COUNT OLAF:** *(inspects the plates)* What? No roast beef?

**KLAUS:** You didn't tell us you ***wanted*** roast beef.

**VIOLET:** We made *******Puttanesca . . .

**COUNT OLAF:** Look at my guests. They can hardly touch this revolting ***foreign*** food!

**TROUP MEMBER 1:** You can't go easy on children. They need to be taught to obey their elders.

**COUNT OLAF:** I demand that you serve roast beef to myself and my guests! *(grabs Violet)*

*******Scene Change – theme song*******

**COUNT OLAF:** *(addressing Violet and Klaus)* I want you children to feel more at home here, now that I am your father. As you know, I have been working hard with my theater troupe, and I'm afraid I may have acted a bit standoffish. I want you to participate in my next play: *(with flourish)* The Marvelous Marriage. It tells the story of a very handsome man, played by me. (thinking) Violet, Violet, Violet . . . you will be playing the young woman I marry. It's a ***very*** important role! Although you only have one line. I think you you know what it is.

**VIOLET:** I don't.

**COUNT OLAF:** No, no, no. It's, I DO.

**VIOLET:** Count Olaf . . .

**COUNT OLAF:** *(threateningly)* What did you call me?

**VIOLET:** *(wincing)* Father . . . I'm not sure I'm talented enough. I'd hate to disgrace your good name.

**COUNT OLAF:** You ***will*** participate! I would prefer it if you participate voluntarily, but I can act *loco parentheses*.

**KLAUS:** ********_In loco parentis_.

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**COUNT OLAF:** Poco De Laurentiis! The point is, I can order you to participate and you must obey. Now, go!I can't stand you anymore.

*******Scene Change to Justice Strauss House – theme song*******

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** *(Violet and Klaus knock at the door; Justice Straus answers)* Baudelaires! I'm so happy to see you!

**KLAUS:** Justice Strauss, can I ask you something?"

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** Certainly.

**KLAUS:** *(opening a rather large legal book, he reads)* ***"The only nuptial requirements are a statement of active acquiescence by participants, utilizing <u>in loco parentis</u> if necessary, and the signing of a document in the bride's own hand."*** *(looks up)* Does that mean what I think it means?

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** Well, I suppose it depends upon what you think it means.

**COUNT OLAF:** *(abruptly looms behind Klaus; to Strauss)* It means you're going to be a star!

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** Count Olaf!

**COUNT OLAF:** Please, call me your guardian actor. Justice Strauss, you are about to find your drab, legal beagle existence transformed into something mind-blowing, and yet extremely classy, when you become the exciting new face of the next Count Olaf production . . . *(with great theatrics)* The curtain rises. The audience applauds! *(demanding look to Violet and Klaus, who both applaud)* And you walk onto stage dressed as . . . . a judge!

**JUSTICE STRAUSS:** *(fan-girling)* I get to share the stage with Count Olaf?

**COUNT OLAF:** You will stand in front of a very handsome me while a stunningly-costumed bride, played by Violet *(she makes a face)* stands beside me. You will perform the wedding ceremony, getting each and every word exactly right . . . while we sign a document which you shall bring from City Hall, for added realism.

**VIOLET:** *(to audience)* This is terrible . . . terrible! I'm not old enough to get married!

**KLAUS:** *(to audience)* If my sister says "I do" and signs a piece of paper while Justice Strauss is in the room, she's legally married. This play won't be pretend. It'll be real and legally binding.

*******Scene Change to SHOWTIME – theme song*******

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**TROUPE MEMBER 1:** Showtime!

**COUNT OLAF:** *(takes the stage)* Please, duchess. What is a very handsome man like me to do . . . *(clears throat)*

**TROUPE MEMBER 1:** By the turrets of Gravelstein, this very handsome man shall be mine.

**TROUPE MEMBER 2:** By the Gardens of Worthington, if I can't have him, my heart will break.

**BOTH:** He's so handsome! He's so handsome!"

**COUNT OLAF:** My wedding day. *(wedding march plays as Violet, Klaus and Justice Strauss take the stage)*

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** *(to Count Olaf)* Do you take this woman to be your lawfully wedded wife?

**COUNT OLAF:** I do.

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** *(turning to Violet)* Do you take this woman?

**COUNT OLAF:** Man!

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** *(correcting herself)* Man. Do you take this man to be your lawfully wedded husband?

**VIOLET:** *(looks apprehensively at Olaf)* I do. *(they both sign a document)*

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** By the powers vested in me, I now pronounce you Count and Countess. *(Olaf tries to Kiss Violet, but she turns her head away)*

**COUNT OLAF:** *(proud of himself, he breaks character)* Ladies and gentlemen, I'd like to make an announcement. There is no need to continue with tonight's performance. Its purpose has been served. My marriage to Violet Baudelaire is legal, and I am now in control of her entire fortune.

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** *(shocked)* That can't be true!

**COUNT OLAF:** The law clearly states that the bride must say "I do" and sign the appropriate document *(holds up document)*

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** *(bewildered, she scans the document)* I'm afraid this marriage is legally binding. I am so sorry. I can't believe how easily I was tricked.

**COUNT OLAF:** *(gleefully)* You were! It was child's play, winning this fortune. And now a reception to celebrate my special day! *(to Violet)* Care to dance, Countess?

**VIOLET:** I'm not a Countess. At least I don't think I am.

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**COUNT OLAF:** Why not?

**VIOLET:** I didn't sign the document in my own hand as the law states.

**COUNT OLAF:** Don't lie to me, orphan. Everyone saw you!

**VIOLET:** But I'm right-handed, and I signed the document with my left.

**COUNT OLAF:** *(scoffs)* Well, that doesn't count. You're just being a sore loser and trying to ruin my special day.

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** *(looks at the document again, then to Olaf)* You are a vile and terrible person. And I am happy to say that because Violet, who is right-handed, signed the document with her left hand, the marriage is invalid!

**KLAUS:** *(cheers)*

**JUSTICE STRAUS:** [Furthermore] the Baudelaires will be sent to a suitable guardian!

**TOGETHER:** And this series of unfortunate events has come to a close *(bows)*

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Daniel Handler (aka Lemony Snickett) and Joe Tracz***
***based on The Bad Beginning: Part 1 by Lemony Snickett***
***TV Transcript: Season 1, Episodes 1 & 2***
***https://snicket.fandom.com/wiki/A_Bad_Beginning:_Part_One/Transcript***
***https://snicket.fandom.com/wiki/A_Bad_Beginning:_Part_Two/Transcript***
***ISBN: On-line Transcripts***
***Publisher: Netflix***
***Date (Month/Year): 2017***

## AWARD HISTORY

***2025 National Qualifier***

** A Series of Unfortunate Events – Theme Song*
*https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0GeCPanRHU0*

*** It's the Count (music and lyrics)*
*https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tl7JZ8_8v44*

**** Puttanesca is a quick, flavorful Italian pasta from Naples, featuring a sauce of tomatoes, olives, capers, garlic, and anchovies, often with chili flakes for heat.*

***** A Latin legal term meaning "in the place of a parent."*

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